Between Shades of Gray

By Ruta Sepetys

LINA: **(Pg 26-27)** They were taking Jonas. My beautiful, sweet brother who shooed bugs out of the house instead of stepping on them.

JONAS: Mama! Lina! *(he hangs his head and cries)*

LINA: Mother grabbed the officer and began speaking in Russian – pure, fluent Russian. The officer jerked Jonas toward him. His body began to vibrate as sobs wracked his shoulders. Mother pulled a bundle of rubles from her pocket. Her hand flew up and ripped the amber pendant from her neck and pressed it into the officer's hand. He didn't seem satisfied. Mother pulled a pocket watch from her coat. I knew that watch. It was her fathers' and had his name engraved on the back. The officer snatched the watch and let go of Jonas.

Have you ever wondered what a human life is worth? That morning, my brother's was worth a pocket watch.

INTRODUCTION

The year was 1941. While Adolf Hitler orchestrated his "Final Solution" against the Jewish population, Joseph Stalin took the opportunity to target "anti-Soviet" elements in the Baltic States where anyone with a prestigious job, regardless of religion, was viewed as a potential threat to Stalin's power.

Overshadowed by the atrocities of Hitler's extermination camps, history is eerily quiet regarding Stalin's Great Purge. More than a million people from Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania were loaded onto cattle cars. The destination: forced labor camps in Siberia.

This is the story of Lina Vilkas, only 15 when Stalin's Great Purge begins. Can Lina keep her humanity as she navigates . . .

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MAMA: **(Pg 7)** *(frantically)* Shoes, Jonas, extra socks, a coat! Lina . . . Hurry!

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LINA: **(Pg 11)** The door burst open and three officers entered our house carrying rifles with bayonets. Mother looked in the foyer mirror to put on her hat. The officer slammed her in the shoulder with the butt of his rifle, throwing her face-first into the mirror.

OFFICER: Bourgeois pigs, always wasting time. You won't need that hat.

MAMA: *(flatly without making eye contact)* Pardon me.

LINA: ***Pardon me?*** These men burst into our home, slam her into the mirror and she asks them to pardon ***her***? Then she reached for it, the long gray coat, and suddenly I understood. She was playing the Soviet officers like a careful hand of cards, not quite sure what might be dealt next. I saw her in my mind, sewing jewelry, papers, silver and other valuables into the coat's lining.

OFFICER: **(Pg 13)** ***Davai!*** ***(Hurry!)***

LINA: We marched into the intersection of the street toward a truck surrounded by more NKVD***** **(Pg 14)** We were all on the list. I didn't know what the list was only that we were on it. Apparently so were the other fifteen people sitting inside on their luggage. **(Pg 15)** I squeezed my eyes shut. The truck stopped in front of the hospital. Waiting. A woman who was also on the list was giving birth to a baby. As soon as the umbilical cord was cut, they would both be thrown into the truck.

ONA: **(Pg 20)** *(Screaming)* My baby! Please don't hurt my baby!

DOCTOR: Please, you cannot take the newborn. It won't survive! Sir, I beg you. Please!

LINA: The officer turned to the doctor and kicked the heel of his boot into the doctor's kneecap. They lifted the woman into the truck. The baby was handed up. I held the bundle and instantly felt the warmth of its little body penetrating through my coat. The child let out a soft cry and its tiny fists pummeled the air. Its fight for life had begun. **(Pg 21)** The child had been alive only minutes but was already considered a criminal by the Soviets.

(Pg 23) We arrived at a small train depot in the countryside. A deserted area, surrounded by dark woods. Soviet trucks filled the rail yard, packed with people just like ours. I pictured a rug being lifted and a huge Soviet broom sweeping us under it.

(Pg 29) Wooden train cars lined the platform, stretching as far as the eye could see. They were crudely built and dirty, the kind that would haul livestock. Masses of Lithuanians thronged toward them. White knuckles clutching suitcases. People on their knees yrying bags with twine while officers stepped on the contents. **(Pg 35)** I counted the people – 46 packed in a cage on wheels. Faces spoke to their future. Courage, anger, fear and confusion. Others had already given up. Which was I?

(Pg 41) The back of our train car had Russian writing on it. Thieves and prostitutes. Mothers were in that car. Along with a teacher, a librarian, elderly people, and a newborn baby – thieves and prostitutes. **(Pg 49)** Two Soviets pulled a priest down the platform. His hands were bound and his cassock was dirty. Why a priest? But then . . . why any of us?

MAMA: **(Pg 51)** Stalin has a plan. The Kremlin will do anything to see it through. He wants Lithuania for the Soviet Union. I imagine he's doing the same to Latvia, Estonia and Finland.

LINA: **(Pg 55)** I hated them, the NKVD and the Soviets. I planted a seed of hatred in my heart. It would grow to be a massive tree whose roots would strangle them all. I looked around the train car. No one spoke. How could we stand up for ourselves if everyone cowered in fear and refused to speak?

(Pg 62-63) While I devised a plan, the women in the car showed constant concern for the baby, who could not seem to nurse. We rolled for days, stopping in the middle of nowhere. **(Pg 50)** A guard approached and handed up a bucket of water and a buckry of slop.

GUARD: **(Pg 64)** One person! Two buckets! Any dead bodies in there?

LINA: Ona was quiet. Her baby was dead.

MAMA: **(Pg 71)** Ona, dear. Give me the baby.

ONA: *(begging)* Don't give her to them. Please!

MAMA: We will not give her to the guards. I promise. We'll wrap her in something beautiful.

LINA: **(Pg 75-76)** We tried for three days to sneak Ona's baby out. The smell of rotting flesh had become unbearable in the hot car. Ona finally agreed to drop the baby down the bathroom hole.

ONA: *(whimpering)* She'll be crushed on the tracks. . .

LINA: Mother moved toward Ona. Before she reached her, Miss Grybas snapped the bundle from Ona and threw it down the hole. *(gasp)* **(Pg 82)** Ona was only a few years older than me.

(Pg 78) Weeks . . . I lost track of how long we had been traveling. I stopped watching for bodies to be hurled from the cars. Every time the train pulled away, we left a litter of corpses in our wake. Would someone bury them, or would they believe they were really thieves and prostitutes?

(Pg 80-81) After six weeks and the third day without food, the train stopped. We heard clanking. The guards opened the door and said we would be getting out. Finally. My entire body trembled at the shock of daylight. The NKVD had bayoneted rifles at the ready.

ONA: **(Pg 94)** *(crying and rocking back and forth unconsolably she chants)* No, no, no, no!

LINA: **(Pg 101)** She could not be calmed. The commander saw Ona standing up, sitting down, and pulling her hair. He stepped up and pulled her from the truck.

ONA: **(Pg 94)** No, no, no, no! *(Screaming and clawing at him as if being drug by her hair)*

LINA: **(Pg 101)** She was no match for his height or strength. He threw her to the ground. His eyes narrowed. His jaw tightened . . . *(in horror)* He pulled out a pistol and shot Ona in the head. *(long beat, then with little emotion -- dazed)*

(Pg 102) Blood, the color of thick red wine. Leg splayed out in an unnatural angle. One of her feet was missing a shoe. Ona's body got smaller and smaller as we drove away. She lay dead in the dirt, murdered by the NKVD. Somewhere hundreds of miles away, her daughter decomposed in the grass. *(long beat, reflective)* **(Pg 163-164)** My art teacher said if you breathed deeply and imagined something, you could be there. I

learned to do that. I clung to my rusted dreams during times of silence. At gun point, I fell into every hope and allowed myself to wish from the deepest part of my heart. **(Pg 112)** What ***had*** happened to Ona? Was she in heaven with her daughter? Or was she floating amongst the trains and masses of Lithuanians, searching for her husband?

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(Pg 3) They took me in my nightgown. Thinking back, the signs were there – family photos burned in the fireplace. Mother sewing her best silver and jewelry into the lining of her coat. Only later did I realize that Mother and Father intended we escape. We did not escape. We were taken . . . June 14, 1941.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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**** NKVD - the Soviet Secret Police***

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